Bua Khiao Pharmacy Launches ClearLabel: Large-Print, Picture and Spoken Medicine Labels for Older and Visually Impaired Patients

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SURAT THANI, 1 October 2026 – Bua Khiao Pharmacy, a family-owned community pharmacy group with seven branches in Surat Thani province, today announced ClearLabel, an accessible labelling service for people who struggle to read the small print on medicine packs. From 1 November 2026, patients at the Talat Lang, Kanchanadit and Phunphin branches will be able to ask for labels in large print, labels with picture symbols for the time of day, and spoken labels that can be played back on a small handheld reader. The remaining four branches will follow in two stages during early 2027.

The service grew out of a review of dispensing errors reported to the pharmacy group in 2025. Of 64 incidents in which a patient took a medicine at the wrong time or in the wrong amount at home, 27 involved a patient aged over 70 who later told the pharmacist that they "could not read the sticker".

1. What ClearLabel includes

ClearLabel is not a single label but a set of three options. A patient can choose one, two or all three, and the choice is saved on the patient's record so that it is applied automatically to every future prescription.

1.1 Large-print labels

The large-print label prints the medicine name, the dose and the instructions in 16-point bold type on a white background, compared with the 9-point type used on Bua Khiao's standard dispensing label. Because the text is larger, the label is printed on a wider 70 mm sticker that wraps around the box or bottle, and a second copy is supplied loose in a clear plastic sleeve for the patient's medicine diary. Instructions are written in plain words: "Take 1 tablet in the morning after breakfast" rather than abbreviations.

1.2 Picture labels

Picture labels add a row of four symbols to the large-print label: a rising sun for morning, a full sun for midday, a setting sun for evening and a moon for bedtime. The symbols for the times when the medicine should be taken are printed in solid black; the others are shown as faint outlines. A separate symbol of a plate shows whether the medicine is taken with food. A printed key to the symbols is given to the patient.

1.3 Spoken labels

For patients who are blind or have very low vision, the pharmacist can attach a small round sticker containing a coded audio recording. When the SpeakDot reader, a pen-sized device, is touched to the sticker, it plays the medicine name, the dose and the instructions aloud in Thai, or in English, Burmese or Southern Thai dialect on request. Each recording is made by the dispensing pharmacist at the counter and lasts up to 30 seconds. The reader works with any SpeakDot sticker, so one device covers all of a patient's medicines.

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2. Who can use the service

ClearLabel is open to any patient who has a prescription or a pharmacy medicine dispensed at a Bua Khiao branch that offers the service. Patients do not need to prove a visual impairment to receive large-print or picture labels; it is enough to ask. Carers and family members may request the service on behalf of the person who takes the medicine, provided that person is registered as a Bua Khiao patient.

Large-print, picture and spoken labels are free of charge for medicines dispensed by Bua Khiao. There is no limit on the number of items per visit.

2.1 Medicines dispensed elsewhere

Patients may also bring medicines dispensed by a hospital or clinic and ask for them to be relabelled. The pharmacist will relabel an item only if it is still in its original pack and the original dispensing label, showing the patient's name and the prescriber's directions, is still attached and readable. The ClearLabel sticker is added next to the original label, never on top of it. Bua Khiao charges 30 baht per item for relabelling medicines dispensed elsewhere. This fee is waived for patients aged 75 or over and for holders of a disability identification card.

> **Note.** Medicines that must be kept in a refrigerator, such as insulin pens and some eye drops, and any medicine with a loose or missing original label cannot be relabelled from another provider. The pharmacist will instead give the patient a large-print instruction card to keep with the medicine.

2.2 Borrowing a SpeakDot reader

Patients who choose spoken labels can borrow a SpeakDot reader from the branch for as long as they need it. A refundable deposit of 500 baht is taken when the reader is issued and is returned in full when the reader is brought back in working order. The deposit is waived for holders of a disability identification card. During the pilot in 2026 the deposit was 300 baht; it has been raised because of the cost of replacing lost devices.

3. How to ask for ClearLabel

Patients or carers can sign up at the counter at any time when the branch pharmacist is on duty. The steps are:

1. Tell the counter staff that you would like ClearLabel and show your Bua Khiao patient card or national ID card so that your record can be found.
2. The pharmacist asks which options you want (large print, pictures, spoken labels) and, for spoken labels, which language the recording should use.
3. The pharmacist records your choice on your patient record and asks you to sign the ClearLabel consent slip, which allows the pharmacy to keep the setting for future prescriptions.
4. If you have chosen spoken labels, the pharmacist issues a SpeakDot reader, takes the deposit if it applies, and shows you how to use it on your first medicine.
5. Before you leave, the pharmacist reads each new label back to you, or plays the recording, and checks that you understand when to take each medicine.

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Patients who cannot visit in person may sign up by telephone through the ClearLabel line on 077 281 460, open Monday to Saturday from 09:00 to 17:00. A carer collecting medicines must then bring the signed consent slip on the next visit. Settings can be changed or cancelled at any time at the counter or by telephone.

4. Rollout to all branches

ClearLabel was tested from April to August 2026 at the Talat Lang branch, where 212 patients signed up. The full rollout runs in three phases:

- Phase 1, from 1 November 2026: Talat Lang, Kanchanadit and Phunphin branches.
- Phase 2, from 11 January 2027: Chaiya and Don Sak branches.
- Phase 3, from 1 March 2027: Ban Na San and Wiang Sa branches.

Large-print and picture labels will be available at every branch from the first day of its phase. Spoken labels and SpeakDot readers will reach the phase 3 branches two weeks later, on 15 March 2027, once staff there have completed training.

In a follow-up survey of 150 pilot patients, 88 percent said they found their medicines easier to manage, and the Talat Lang branch recorded no wrong-time incidents among ClearLabel patients during the five-month pilot.

5. Quotes

"Many of our older patients were too polite to tell us that they could not read the label. ClearLabel means they no longer have to ask a grandchild to read it for them," said Kesinee Boonmalert, Pharmacist-in-Charge at Bua Khiao Pharmacy, who led the pilot.

"We are a small pharmacy group, but we believe the safest medicine is one the patient understands. We are funding ClearLabel ourselves, and no patient will pay for a label on a medicine we dispense," said Phichai Rattanakorn, Managing Director of Bua Khiao Pharmacy.

6. Notes for editors

- Bua Khiao Pharmacy Co., Ltd. was founded in Surat Thani in 1998 and employs 19 pharmacists across seven branches. Its head office is at the Talat Lang branch.
- ClearLabel does not change any medicine, dose or prescription. It changes only how the instructions are presented to the patient.
- Photographs of sample labels and a short video of the SpeakDot reader are available to the media on request.
- Journalists who would like to see the service in use may visit the Talat Lang branch on weekday mornings by appointment.

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